Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 1 (Academic + Wiki) — Course Overview & Framing

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Today

1. Course Overview
2. Why Academic Writing Matters
3. Global Structure
4. Your First Writing Task
5. What's Coming
6. (Wiki) Orientation & Onboarding

Roadmap

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What This Course Is About

This course is about learning to write better.

- Academic vs. encyclopedic writing (audience, voice, structure)
- Sustainable knowledge: FAIR / CARE, openness, ethics
- Practice both: (Academic) paper and (Wiki) article
  - focusing on environmental issues
- Learn transferable skills: argument, evaluation, revision, collaboration

We care more about content than style.

Practicalities

- Everything is on the course website
  - schedule, assessment, deadlines, readings, these slides
- Tuesdays 16:45, Room 3.51, tř. Svobody 26
  - Francis: 90 minutes, **16:45–18:15**
  - Pavel: three hours, 16:45–19:45, with the new material in the first 90 minutes and practice after, so you can finish at home if you must leave
- Pavel teaches in Czech, Francis in English
- In cooperation with Wikimedia ČR and the Asian Month on Czech Wikipedia (November)

Two Paths to Better Writing

(Academic) Short paper (4–8 pp *plus* refs)

- Argument-driven, thesis-focused
- Synthesis and analysis
- Scholarly voice & citation norms
- Writing part of a larger process

(Wiki) Wikipedia article

- Neutral, verifiable, no original research
- Clear structure; accessibility
- Community standards, consensus

- One goal: **knowledge others can trust, find and build on**
- We **compare genres** to strengthen writing and judgment

Academic vs. Encyclopedic Writing

	(Academic) paper	**(Wiki) article**
Audience	specialists	general public
Purpose	argue something new	summarise what is known
Voice	hedged, theory-aware	neutral, accessible
Evidence	engage the literature	cite reliable secondary sources
Structure	thesis / IMRaD	lede + sections

IMRaD = Introduction, Methods, Results, and Discussion

- Wikipedia's **neutral point of view** (NPOV) and **no original research**: an article reports what reliable sources say, it does not argue

Using AI in this course

- **Not for writing.** You are here to practise writing. The words in your paper and your Wikipedia article must be your own.
  - This includes **proofreading**: a model would rewrite your sentences into fluent, anonymous English. Spell-checker yes; rewrite no. For help with language, ask us.
- **For research, with disclosure.** Use it to explain a concept, suggest search terms, or point you towards literature.
- **Say what you used**, naming the tool and the version, and what you used it for:
  - *Claude Opus 5 (Anthropic) was used to suggest search terms. All sources were located, read, and cited by me.*
- What a model tells you is a lead, not a source: find the original, **read** it, and cite that.
- Undisclosed use counts as academic misconduct.
- Full policy, and how assessment works, on the course website.

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Why It Matters

- It **helps thinking**: analysis, structure, precision
- It **builds knowledge**: claims + evidence + reasoning
- It **travels**: others can reuse, critique, extend
- It **signals credibility**: method, transparency, sources
- It **connects communities**: researchers, practitioners, public

Write for your Audience

Three questions to ask before you write:

- **Who are they?** terminology, the arguments they expect
- **What do they already know?** assume that, explain the rest
- **What do they want from you?** that depends:

Writing for	**they want**
basic research	understanding
applied research	better practice
literary studies	better appreciation
the fine arts	to be engaged
Wikipedia	an answer, quickly

- Different disciplines are interested in different things (not always sensibly)

Define Your Purpose

- Explain, evaluate, compare, propose, synthesize?
- Purpose drives selection of evidence and structure
- One paper should have one clear purpose
  - **Specific**: a claim you can support in a short paper
  - **Contestable**: not a truism; invites argument
  - **Roadmap**: hints at reasons/structure to come

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Common Structures

- Humanities: **thesis-driven essay**
- Social and natural sciences: **IMRaD** (+ Conclusion)
- Linguistics:
  Intro → Background → Data/Methods → Analysis → Discussion → Conclusion
- Computer Science:
  Intro → Related Work → Method → Data → Experiments/Results → Analysis → Conclusion
- Hybrids: literature review + case study; policy analysis + recommendations

Start and End Well

- The Introduction sets the stage
  - Context → Problem → Question/Claim → Contribution → Roadmap
  - Avoid: history lessons without focus; claims with no stakes
- The Conclusion drives home the argument
  - Answer the question; synthesize findings
  - State implications, limits, next steps
  - **Avoid**: repeating the intro; new evidence in the last paragraph

A Minimal Model Outline

- **Abstract** (150–200 words)
- **Introduction**: context, question, thesis, roadmap
- **Body**: 2–3 sections building your case
- **Conclusion**: answer, implications, limits
- **References**: consistent style (we will use APA)

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Compare three kinds of Writing

Do data centres use too much water?

- An **encyclopedia** summarises what is known
  - *Environmental impact of AI*, the *Water usage* section (Wikipedia contributors, 2026)
- An **academic paper** argues a case, hedged and cited
  - Mytton (2021), *Data centre water consumption* — six pages, open access
- A **blog post** argues a case too, but by its own rules
  - Masley (2025), *The AI water issue is fake*

All three describe the same world. They disagree about how much it matters.

Write Three Paragraphs (by Sunday 11 October)

- Read all three, then write roughly 400–500 words:
  - **What does each one claim?** State it in one sentence each
  - **Where do they differ**, and is it about the facts or about what the facts mean?
  - **Which did you trust most, and why?** Name what convinced you — evidence, sources, hedging, tone
- Post it on Moodle by Sunday 11 October, and bring it to class on 13 October
- **Your own words**: no generative AI. Cite the three sources and anything else you read.
- Not graded. We use it to see how you write; you use it to practise reading like a writer. We come back to it on 13 October.

What a Paragraph Should Do

- One paragraph, one point
- **Topic sentence first**: the reader knows the point before the detail
- Then support it: evidence, example, or reason
- End by linking to what comes next
- Read it aloud — if you run out of breath, the sentence is too long

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The Rest of the Course

Date	Who	What
29 Sep	Pavel	Wikipedia rules: accounts, sandboxes, the five pillars
6 Oct	Francis	Academic vs. encyclopedic writing: what is your message?
13 Oct	Francis	Finding, judging and citing sources
20 Oct	—	*Reading and writing week*: no class
27 Oct	Francis	FAIR: making data findable and reusable
3 Nov	Pavel	Writing a good Wikipedia article
10 Nov	Francis	CARE, ethics, and honest persuasion
17 Nov	—	*Public holiday*: no class
24 Nov	Pavel	Feedback on Wikipedia articles
1 Dec	Francis	Peer review: how it works
8 Dec	Francis	Peer review: doing it — bring your draft
15 Dec	both	Conclusions and reflection

Both assignments are due in January — dates and weights on the course website.

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(Wiki) Ground Rules

- Wikipedia **Five pillars** (Wikipedia contributors, 2025)
- **UCoC**: Universal Code of Conduct (Wikimedia Foundation, 2021)
- **Programs & Events Dashboard** enrollment (Wiki Education, 2025)
- Starter modules: editing basics, sourcing, plagiarism

Before Next Time

- Create a Wikipedia account and enrol on the Dashboard
- **29 September**: Pavel's session on Wikipedia, in Czech
- **11 October**: post your three paragraphs on Moodle
- Start noticing environmental topics you might want to write about

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Appendix

These slides are here for reference. We come back to all of them later in the course.

Choosing and Using Evidence (13 October)

- What can be trusted as evidence?
  - Peer-reviewed articles; scholarly books
  - Policy reports; official statistics; reputable NGOs
  - Data (quantitative/qualitative), corpora, case studies
- Evaluating sources
  - **Authority**: who wrote it? venue? peer review?
  - **Recency/Relevance**: up-to-date, on-point
  - **Method/Transparency**: can you inspect or replicate?

Integrating Sources

- **Summarize**: key point in your words, with citation
- **Paraphrase**: reframe to serve your argument
- **Quote**: sparingly, when wording is crucial
- Always connect source to **your** claim
- Multiple sources are best
  - Weave multiple sources to make a new point
  - Compare/contrast findings, methods, assumptions
  - Identify gaps, tensions, implications

Multilingual Source Literacy

- Often sources in other languages are ignored
- When English is not the richest source: local journals, government docs, linguistic data, …
- Beware translation bias; summarize fairly
- Cross-check facts across languages

Academic Integrity

- Cite all sources (including data, images)
  - Read what you cite, don't cite transitively (or acknowledge when you do)
  - Cite in detail — give page numbers (especially for books)
- Proper paraphrase: change structure and wording, cite anyway
- Avoid patchwriting; keep notes disciplined
- Never fabricate a source — and never trust a model's citation until you have found it

Sustainable Knowledge (27 October)

This is more about data than writing, but still very important.

- **FAIR**: Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable Wilkinson et al., 2016
- **CARE**: Collective benefit, Authority, Responsibility, Ethics Carroll et al., 2020
- **Open Science** (UNESCO Recommendation) UNESCO, 2021
- **Knowledge equity** (Wikimedia 2030) Wikimedia Foundation, 2020

Writing is Revising (8 December)

- Draft fast; revise for structure, then style
  - **Content is more important than presentation**
- Read aloud; reverse outline; get feedback early
- Track changes; keep a revision log

Peer Review is part of the process

- Helpful feedback
  - Focus on **claims, evidence, logic**, not just grammar
  - Ask: what is the thesis? is it supported? what is missing?
  - Offer specific, actionable suggestions
  - Don't be reviewer three
- Responding to Feedback
  - Separate criticism into categories (structure, evidence, style)
  - Decide: change, clarify, or justify (with reasons)
  - Write a brief **revision memo**: what changed and why

Common Mistakes

Mistake	**Fix**
Topic too broad	narrow to a question you can answer with the evidence you have
Claim without evidence	support it, and show how the evidence bears on the claim
Source dump	synthesize; explain why each source matters *for your thesis*
Structure drift	reverse outline; re-order sections to match the argument
Jargon overload	define key terms once; prefer plain English or Czech

Pre-Submission Checklist

- Clear thesis in the introduction
- Section headings reflect argumentative moves
- Each paragraph has a topic sentence and a purpose
- Claims are cited; sources are integrated (not just quoted)
- Figures/tables are labeled and discussed
- Proofread for clarity, concision, coherence

What Good Work Looks Like

- **Clarity**: readers always know the claim & why it matters
- **Evidence**: claims anchored to credible sources
- **Ethics**: accurate attribution; respectful tone; UCoC compliance
- **Sustainability**: work that others can find, reuse, build upon